

The Sūtra of the Great Kāśyapa

Mahākāśyapa Sūtra · Toh 40 · Derge Kangyur

འདོ་སངས་ཆེན་པོའི་མཛད་

The Sūtra of the Great Kāśyapa, known in Sanskrit as the Mahākāśyapa Sūtra and in Tibetan as Ösung Chenpo'i Do (འདོ་སངས་ཆེན་པོའི་མཛད་), is a Buddhist sūtra recounting a direct encounter between the Buddha and his senior disciple Mahākāśyapa. The text opens with Mahākāśyapa lying gravely ill in the Pippalī cave near Rājagṛha, whereupon the Buddha himself comes to visit him, setting the stage for teachings arising out of that compassionate exchange. As a sūtra, it belongs to the discourses attributed to the historical Buddha and preserved in narrative form, centering on themes of illness, spiritual endurance, and the relationship between teacher and disciple. It is Toh 40 in the Kangyur, the collection of canonical texts regarded as the word of the Buddha in the Tibetan tradition, and it falls within the general category of sūtras.

...the seat of the masters. Translated, collated, and definitively established at the great temple Paltharpaling.

In the language of India: Mahākāśyapa Sūtra. In the language of Tibet: The Sūtra of the Great Kāśyapa (Mahākāśyapa, "Protector of Light").

With reverence I bow to the noble Three Jewels.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling in Rājagṛha, in the Bamboo Grove of Kalandaka.

At that time the venerable Mahākāśyapa was staying in the cave of Pippalī, afflicted by a severe illness and suffering greatly.

Then the Blessed One, in the evening, reflected individually on everything as he sat. He made his way to where the venerable Mahākāśyapa was, approached him, and sat down on a seat that had been prepared. Having sat, the Blessed One then spoke these words to the venerable Mahākāśyapa:

"Kāśyapa, how do you fare with food? How do you experience the suffering? How shall it come to be pacified? The pain that has not yet been pacified — it shall be pacified by the method of pacification."

Then the venerable Mahākāśyapa replied: "Reverend One, I have come to have no appetite for food or drink. I am afflicted by a severe illness, and I do not know whether it shall be pacified or not. Please, Reverend One, apply the

method of pacification."

"I shall teach you these seven limbs of awakening (Skt. bodhyaṅga) well. When one cultivates them extensively, one comes to direct knowledge, to awakening, and to nirvāṇa.

What are the seven? Kāśyapa, right mindfulness — this limb of awakening I declare to be a limb of perfect awakening. When one cultivates it extensively, one comes to direct knowledge, to awakening, and to nirvāṇa.

Again, Kāśyapa, investigation of phenomena — this I declare to be a limb of perfect awakening. When one cultivates it extensively, one comes to direct knowledge, to awakening, and to nirvāṇa.

Again, Kāśyapa, right diligence — this I declare to be a limb of perfect awakening. When one cultivates it extensively, one comes to direct knowledge, to awakening, and to nirvāṇa.

Again, Kāśyapa, right joy — this I declare to be a limb of perfect awakening. When one cultivates it extensively, one comes to direct knowledge, to awakening, and to nirvāṇa.

Again, Kāśyapa, right pliancy — this I declare to be a limb of perfect awakening. When one cultivates it extensively, one comes to direct knowledge, to awakening, and to nirvāṇa.

Again, Kāśyapa, right meditative absorption — this I declare to be a limb of perfect awakening. When one cultivates it extensively, one comes to direct knowledge, to awakening, and to nirvāṇa.

Again, Kāśyapa, right equanimity — this I declare to be a limb of perfect awakening. When one cultivates it extensively, one comes to direct knowledge, to awakening, and to nirvāṇa.

Kāśyapa, these are the seven limbs of awakening that I have declared. When one cultivates them extensively, one comes to direct knowledge, to awakening, and to nirvāṇa. One should train in the limbs of awakening as taught by the Blessed Tathāgata."

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the venerable Mahākāśyapa rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said. Immediately, the illness was pacified, and the venerable...

Translator's Notes

- The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end with "□□□" — the passage is incomplete as supplied.

The term "□□□□□□□□□□" (Pippalī cave) is the cave traditionally associated with Mahākāśyapa near Rājagṛha; this corresponds to the Pāli Pipphalī-guhā.

The term "□□□□□□□□□□□□□□" rendered as "pliancy" corresponds to Sanskrit prasrabdhi, the fifth of the seven bodhyaṅgas, a state of mental and physical serviceability or tranquility — distinct from equanimity and from calm abiding, though related. Some translators render it as "serenity" or "tranquility."

The opening fragment ("the seat of the masters... Paltharpaling") is the colophon of a preceding text that ends here; it belongs to no part of the Mahākāśyapa Sūtra itself.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.